

Blinding Lights — Practice Sheet

Aaron Ellis · built from your take 1 (home, 7 Oct 2026) measured note-by-note against The Weeknd's original · vowel runs from your own vowel-code sheet

You can sing these notes. You're holding the wrong ones.

In the original, The Weeknd **holds the “Ooh”s** (about 3 seconds each) and **clips the line endings** short. You do the opposite: shorter Oohs, long endings. The long endings are where your pitch drops. **Every one of your worst-pitch notes is a line ending you held too long.**

What your take showed

Measure	The Weeknd	You	What it means
Chorus “Ooh” (F4)	held ~3.0 s	2.2–2.5 s	give these more time
Endings: lights / night (E♭4)	clipped, ~0.6 s	held 1.5–2.6 s	the main fix
Time spent on D4 (not in the song's key)	2.0 s	12.8 s	your E♭s drooping flat
Time spent on E4 (not in the key)	1.5 s	8.1 s	your Fs drooping flat
The hook (“...walking by...”)	F4–G4	F3–G3	you sang it an octave low
Phrase endings that sag	—	56%	breath running out

The good news. Your **Oohs are your steadiest notes** — the OO vowel holds pitch well for you. The chorus sits on E♭4–F4, which is inside your strongest mixed zone (A3–B4): this is not a range problem. And clipping the endings **also fixes your breath** — right now one chorus phrase runs 10 seconds without a breath, because there's no gap to breathe in.

Where to listen in your recording

Times are in your actual recording file. Which word sits on which note is read from the repeating chorus pattern, so **check each one by ear**.

File time	Word	What happened
1:28 and 2:24	“night” (E♭4)	held ~2.5 s — your two worst notes
1:18 · 2:14 · 2:47	“lights” (E♭4)	held 1.5–2 s; original clips it
2:18 and 2:51	“touch” (F4)	sagging down to E4
1:11 and 2:07	pre-chorus endings	held ~1.5 s, sagging to D4
2:33 – 2:41	the hook	sung an octave below the original
~2:58 – 3:18	the climax section	mostly not sung (optional — see page 3)

How to read a vowel run

The idea in one sentence: you can only hold a note on a **vowel** — consonants just start and stop it. So a vowel run is the line with the consonants taken out, leaving the vowels in order. **One syllable = one vowel = one sung note.**

Worked example — one line, word by word

Take this chorus line from your sheet: “I said, ooh, I’m blinded by the lights.” Find the vowel in each syllable:

Word	I	said	ooh	I’m	blinded	by	the	lights
Your code	AY	s- EH -d	OO	AY -m	bl- AY -nd- IH -d	b- AY	th- OE	l- AY -ts
Vowel kept	AY	EH	OO	AY	AY · IH	AY	OE	AY

blinded has two syllables, so it gives two vowels.

Strip the consonants, keep the vowels in order — **9 syllables, 9 vowels, 9 notes:**

AY · EH · OO · AY · AY · IH · AY · OE · AY

Then add the timing marks from the original — hold the Ooh, clip the ending, breathe:

AY · EH · OO— · AY · AY · IH · AY · OE · AY• ✓

How the vowels link — the three steps

- 1. Say it.** Speak just the vowels in the line’s rhythm: ah – eh – oooo – ah – ah – ih – ah – uh – ah.
- 2. Sing it, joined.** Sing those vowels on the real melody as **one unbroken sound**: the air never stops, each vowel melts straight into the next. That’s what the dots mean — **link, don’t stop**.
- 3. Put the words back.** Sing the real words, but make each consonant a quick flick in the middle of that same unbroken sound. If the line goes choppy or a note dips, go back to step 2.

Why it works: your pitch and tone only exist on vowels. Practising with the consonants removed trains the part that actually carries the note — and you hear straight away if the line breaks or sags.

The marks

Mark	Meaning	Mark	Meaning
OO—	hold — the full long note (~3 s)	✓	breathe here
AY•	clip — short (under ~½ s), then stop	no mark	a passing vowel — keep it moving

What each code sounds like

Code	Sounds like	Code	Sounds like	Code	Sounds like
AY	"my" (ah → ee) *	EH	"bed"	AO	"law"
EE	"see"	AE	"cat"	OE	lazy "uh" in "sofa"
IH	"sit"	AH	"cup"	OO	"food"
AW	"now" (ah → oo) *	UH	"book"	OW	"go" (oh → oo) *

* **Two-part vowels.** AY, AW and OW are two sounds glued together: hold the **first**, close to the second only at the very last moment. **One correction to your sheet:** your AY covers two sounds. In **I / lights / night / time** it starts on "ah" (as in "my"); in **hey / say / baby / maybe** it starts on "eh" (as in "day").

The chorus — your main fix

Learn the **skeleton** first: just the held notes, in order. This is the shape of the whole chorus.

00— → AY• → AH• → 00— → AY• → AH•

F4 (long) · E♭4 (short) · F4 (short) · F4 (long) · E♭4 (short) · F4 (short)

Line ends...	Vowel run
...the lights	AY · EH · 00— · AY · AY · IH · AY · OE · AY• ✓
...your touch	OW · AY · AE · EE · OE · IH · AY · EE · AO · AH• ✓
...in the night	AY · EH · 00— · AY · AW · IH · IH · OE · AY• ✓
...one I trust	OW · EH · AY · AY · IH · AO · OE · AH · AY · AH• ✓

Three rules for the chorus

1. AY is "ah", then "ee" at the last instant. On the short endings this is quick — just never sit on the "ee": it spreads and pulls you off the note.

2. Stop the note with the final consonant. Every chorus line ends on a stop: light**TS**, night**T**, tou**CH**, trust**T**. Land it on the beat and the note ends clean — that's where the original's crisp cut-offs come from.

3. Keep the "uh" in touch and trust tall. Jaw dropped, space up, so it doesn't collapse flat — your "touch" is drooping to E4.

On the Ooh: it isn't dead still in the original — it moves about two semitones across the hold. Listen to how he shapes it and copy that; don't add your own slide.

Pre-chorus — clip the endings

In the original these are short. You held them about 1.5 s and they sagged to D4.

Line ends...	Vowel run
...empty (oh)	IH · IH · EE · OW · AE · EH · EE · OW• ✓
...judge me (oh)	OW · AH · OE · AW · OE · AH · EE · OW• ✓
...when you're gone	AY · AE · EE · IH · EE · EH · AO · A0• ✓

Second time through, the first line starts on OE instead of IH.

The hook — sing it up the octave

The original sits around **F4-G4** — inside your best zone. Dropping it to F3-G3 takes the energy out of the section.

Line ends...	Vowel run
...let you know	AY · AH · A0 · IH · AY · OE · EH · OO · OW
...on the phone	AY · UH · EH · OE · AY · IH · A0 · OE · OW
...this time (ooh)	IH · EH · OE · EH · OO · OW · IH · AY · (OO)

Optional — the climax after the hook

Over the “hey, hey, hey” section the original has a long held **G4** (about 3.8 s) and high falsetto flips (D#5-G#5). Your take goes mostly quiet there — that's why you spent 2.4 s on G4 against his 9.5 s. Leave this until the chorus is solid.

The 20-minute session

After your normal warm-up. Five or six days a week.

#	Drill	Min	Moves this number
1	Chorus skeleton on vowels	5	line-end holds 1.5–2.6 s → under 0.7 s
2	Clip with the consonant	5	sagging phrase endings 56% → well under
3	The Ooh on the water jar	5	Oohs 2.2–2.5 s → a steady 3 s
4	Hook up the octave	3	hook F3-G3 → F4-G4
5	Full chorus + record	2	time on D4 / E4: 12.8 / 8.1 s → toward 2.0 / 1.5 s

1 — Chorus skeleton on vowels · 5 min

Play the original quietly. → Sing only the skeleton from page 3, at tempo: long OO, short AY, short AH — twice. → Then sing all four chorus vowel runs, joined (step 2 of “How the vowels link”).

✓ **Doing it right:** the Oohs feel long and the endings feel almost too short, like you're dropping them. That's correct.

2 — Clip with the consonant · 5 min

Speak the chorus words in rhythm. Hit the T, TS and CH exactly on the beat. → Sing it the same way — the consonant is your off-switch. → Breathe in every gap the clip gives you (the ✓ marks).

✓ **Doing it right:** there's a clear gap of silence after each line, and you breathe in it without trying.

3 — The Ooh on the water jar · 5 min

Water-jar rig, tube a few cm under. → Hold F4 for 3 seconds through the tube — five times. → Then sing OO the same way without the tube, then the chorus “Ooh”s in the song.

✓ **Doing it right:** the pitch feels locked and the sound doesn't thin out at the end of the hold.

4 — Hook up the octave · 3 min

Sing the three hook vowel runs at F4-G4 in a light mix — not pushed. → Then the words.

✓ **Doing it right:** it feels speech-like and easy, not belted.

5 — Full chorus + record · 2 min

Sing a full chorus with the breath marks. → Record it on your phone — the same way as take 1, so the takes compare.

✓ **Doing it right:** you finish the chorus with air left, not gasping.

Don't watch a tuner while you sing. You sing in tune when you're not chasing it. These drills fix the timing and the vowels; the pitch follows. Check afterwards with a new recorded take.

What “better” looks like on the next take

- Time on **D4** and **E4** drops toward the original's 2.0 s and 1.5 s (from your 12.8 s and 8.1 s).
- Line endings come in **under about 0.7 s**.
- Sagging phrase endings fall well below **56%**.
- The hook sits at **F4-G4**.

If the minutes happen, the next report reads differently. If they don't, it won't.